

Product Proposal – CSC271 Fall26

Product Proposal: TechTrade

Part I: Business Idea Types

1. Which type of ideas do you think apply to Shyp? Why?

Upon my own examination, Shyp represents a **Simplify** idea, with elements of **Virtualize** and **Remix**. Shyp was designed to make the process of shipping an item much easier. Instead of requiring customers to find a box, package their item, choose a shipping company, and travel to a shipping location, customers could take a picture of the item through the Shyp app and have it picked up, packaged, and shipped for them. Shyp also compared shipping options from carriers such as UPS, FedEx, and USPS to determine an appropriate shipping method.

The idea can also be considered **Virtualize** because the customer could begin and manage the shipping process through a mobile application rather than handling everything in person. It also contains elements of **Remix** because it combines an app-based experience, courier pickup, packaging services, and traditional shipping companies into one service. Overall, I think **Simplify** is the best description because Shyp's primary purpose was to remove the frustrating and tedious steps involved in shipping a package.

2. Which type of ideas do you think apply to Curofy? Why?

Curofy, on the other hand, mainly conveys itself as a **Me Too** and **Remix** idea. Curofy is a professional social networking platform, similar to LinkedIn, designed specifically for doctors.

It allows doctors to find and communicate with other doctors, discuss patient cases, share medical information, and build professional connections. It was essentially applying the concept of social and professional networking to a specialized healthcare market.

This makes it a **Me Too** idea because it takes an established concept—social and professional networking—and adapts it to a specific market: medical professionals. It is also a **Remix** because Curofy combines several existing concepts, including professional networking, messaging, case discussions, medical information sharing, and a professional directory. The founders recognized that doctors were already using platforms such as Facebook and WhatsApp but that those platforms were not designed specifically for secure and organized professional medical communication.

3. Product Hunt Startup Analysis

Startup: MeterMint

MeterMint is a subscription-tracking product that helps users keep track of their subscriptions, similar to RocketMoney, and understand how much they are actually spending on them each year. It was listed as a Product Hunt launch in March 2026.

Description of the idea:

The basic idea behind MeterMint is to help people manage recurring subscriptions. Many people subscribe to streaming services, software, memberships, cloud storage, free trials, and other recurring services. Because these payments are usually automatic, it can be difficult to

understand how much they add up to over an entire year. MeterMint addresses this problem by giving users a way to track their subscriptions and see their total recurring spending.

Type(s) of ideas:

I would classify MeterMint primarily as a **Simplify** idea. The product does not necessarily invent subscriptions or budgeting. Instead, it makes it easier for users to understand and manage something that already exists in their lives. It could also be considered a **Virtualize** idea because it moves manual subscription tracking and financial organization into an automated digital one-stop-shop.

Painkiller or Vitamin?:

I would consider MeterMint closer to a **painkiller** than a vitamin. The product addresses a real financial problem: people can easily lose track of recurring expenses and spend more money than they realize. While subscription tracking is not necessarily an emergency, helping users identify unnecessary expenses can directly save them money.

Is the idea easy to monetize?:

Yes, although there are challenges. A subscription-management product could potentially use a freemium model where basic tracking is free while advanced features, like yearly spending analysis and investment tracking, require a paid subscription. It could also generate revenue through partnerships with financial services or other relevant companies. However, monetization could be difficult because users may not want to pay for a product whose purpose is to help them reduce their expenses.

Is the idea simple and easy to describe?:

Yes. The basic concept can be explained very quickly: **MeterMint helps you track your subscriptions and understand how much they cost you.**

That simplicity is one of the idea's strengths. A user does not need a lengthy explanation to understand its purpose. Is the idea personally relevant? The problem is personally relevant to me because I utilize multiple technology products and services, like Spotify, HBO Max, iCloud+, and my Visible+ cellular plan, that involve recurring monthly costs. Using MeterMint, technology users like myself can easily accumulate subscriptions for software, entertainment, cloud storage, cellular services, and other services in one user-friendly, detailed environment, helping everyone save money.

Does the idea have a large market?:

Yes. Subscription-based services are rampant, and the number of people using recurring digital services makes subscription management relevant to a large number of consumers.

Does the idea have a legitimate secret sauce?:

The basic concept of tracking subscriptions is not completely unique, so the product's secret sauce would need to come from how effectively it presents and analyzes the user's information. For example, a strong version could make it extremely easy to identify unnecessary subscriptions, calculate annual spending, and show users where they could save money. The value would come from the quality and simplicity of the user experience rather than simply having a list of subscriptions.

Part II: Brainstorming

1. Brainstorm ideas of problems I want to solve with software

I considered several problems that could potentially be solved through a website or application:

1. People have difficulty deciding whether to repair or replace aging electronics.
2. Consumers often have difficulty understanding complicated technology specifications when shopping for a new device.
3. Students have assignments, deadlines, and class information spread across multiple platforms.
4. People have difficulty determining what is wrong with a car or other vehicle when they experience a problem.
5. New motorcycle owners may not know what they need to do to purchase, register, insure, and maintain a motorcycle.
6. People have difficulty finding reliable local contractors and communicating with them.
7. Consumers may not know whether a technology upgrade, such as additional storage or memory, is worthwhile.
8. People often accumulate subscriptions without realizing how much they spend each month or year.
9. People have difficulty deciding which technology product is best for their particular needs rather than simply choosing the product with the highest specifications.
10. College students may have difficulty organizing information and resources from multiple classes in one place.

2. Brainstorm ways to solve these problems

Some potential solutions I considered include:

1. A website that analyzes an electronic device and recommends whether the user should **repair, upgrade, sell, or replace** it.
2. A technology recommendation website that asks users about their needs and recommends appropriate products.
3. A student dashboard that combines assignments, deadlines, calendars, and course information.
4. An interactive vehicle troubleshooting tool that helps users identify possible causes of common problems.
5. A beginner motorcycle ownership website containing licensing, registration, maintenance, and purchasing information.
6. A contractor marketplace that allows customers to find contractors, compare services, and schedule appointments.
7. A technology upgrade calculator that estimates whether upgrading an existing device is more cost-effective than replacing it.
8. A subscription tracker that calculates monthly and annual recurring expenses.
9. A technology comparison tool that focuses on real-world use cases instead of only technical specifications.
10. A website that combines student productivity tools into a single interface.

3. Which idea did I choose and why?

I chose **TechTrade**, a website that helps people decide whether they should **repair, upgrade, sell, or replace** their electronics.

I chose this idea because it combines several problems that I am personally interested in, particularly technology, consumer decision-making, and getting the most value out of electronic devices.

I also believe this idea is a good fit for the course because it can be represented effectively through an interactive website. I do not need to build a complete commercial technology marketplace to demonstrate the concept. Instead, I can create a prototype that asks users questions about their device and provides a recommendation.

Another reason I chose TechTrade is that it has a clearly defined problem. I work as a Samsung consultant in Best Buy and guests frequently are confused on whether or not they should buy a new phone outright, do a trade-in, repair, or replace their devices. When I am in the store, I have to compare between their cell carrier, Best Buy trade-in, manufacturer trade-in, and current market value, which is tedious and easily misunderstood. Instead of trying to create a website that does everything related to technology, TechTrade focuses on one specific decision:

What should I do with my current device?

This makes the concept manageable while still giving me opportunities to develop an interesting and useful website.

4. Is the idea new or has it existed before?

The general concept is not completely new. There are already websites and services that provide device trade-in values, repair information, product recommendations, and technology comparisons (as aforementioned). However, TechTrade would combine these concepts around a specific four-option decision: **repair, upgrade, sell, or replace**.

Therefore, I would consider TechTrade an improvement and combination (**Remix and Simplify**) of existing ideas rather than an entirely original invention. This is consistent with the idea that a product does not have to be completely new to be useful. Existing competitors can demonstrate that there is already a market for the problem being addressed.

5. What industry would the idea be useful in?

TechTrade would primarily belong to the **consumer technology and electronics industry**, with connections to the **repair, resale, and e-commerce industries**. The product would be useful in the consumer technology industry because it helps people make decisions about devices such as smartphones, laptops, tablets, gaming consoles, and other electronics. It also connects to the repair and resale industries because TechTrade could help users determine whether repairing or selling an existing device makes more financial sense than purchasing a new one.

Part III: Product Proposal

1. Describe the product and the type(s) of ideas that apply to it.

TechTrade is a web-based decision-making tool that helps consumers determine what they should do with an aging, damaged, or underperforming electronic device.

A user would enter information about their device, including its age, condition, performance, upgrade options, estimated repair cost, and how they currently use the device. TechTrade would then evaluate that information and recommend one of four options:

- **Repair** the device
- **Upgrade** the device
- **Sell** the device
- **Replace** the device

TechTrade is primarily a **Simplify** idea because it simplifies a complicated consumer decision. Instead of requiring users to research repair costs, upgrade options, resale values, and replacement products separately, TechTrade brings these considerations together.

It is also a **Remix** idea because it combines concepts from device diagnostics, product comparison, resale valuation, repair services, and technology recommendations into one product.

2. How is the product personally relevant to you?

Technology is personally relevant to me because I regularly use and research different types of electronics, including computers, smartphones, tablets, and other technology products.

As someone who pays attention to technology specifications, performance, upgrades, pricing, and product lifespans, I have experienced how difficult it can be to determine whether an existing device should be upgraded or replaced.

For someone who is not as familiar with technology, this decision can be even more difficult. I work as a Samsung Experience Consultant in Best Buy where I constantly assist guests in deciding what device will work best with them considering their current device, personal needs, type of employment, and budget. I frequently observe that one person might replace a device unnecessarily when a relatively inexpensive upgrade could have extended its useful life, or they might spend too much money repairing a device that is already approaching the end of its useful lifespan. This makes the problem interesting to me personally and gives me motivation to continue developing the idea throughout the semester.

3. What problem will your product solve?

TechTrade solves the problem of **uncertainty when deciding what to do with aging or damaged electronics**. Consumers often have four possible choices, but determining which choice is financially and practically best can be difficult.

For example, a laptop may be running slowly. The user could spend money repairing it, upgrade its storage or memory, sell it while it still has value, or replace it with a newer laptop. The best decision depends on several factors, including the device's age, condition, performance, repair cost, upgradeability, resale value, and the user's needs. TechTrade will organize these factors into one simple decision-making process. The goal is not simply to convince users to purchase a new

device. Instead, the goal is to help users make the decision that provides the best value for their particular situation.

4. What type of website will your product be?

TechTrade will be a **web application/prototype** with informational and interactive elements.

The website will introduce the concept and allow users to enter information about their device.

The prototype could include a questionnaire or decision tool that produces a recommendation based on the user's answers.

The website could include pages such as:

- Home
- How It Works
- Device Assessment
- Results/Recommendation
- Repair vs. Replace Information
- About TechTrade

The primary focus will be the interactive device assessment rather than simply providing static information.

5. Is your product a painkiller or a vitamin?

I would consider TechTrade primarily a **painkiller**.

A vitamin is generally something that provides an optional improvement or convenience, while a painkiller addresses a problem that users actively want to solve. TechTrade addresses a real financial and practical problem. Electronics can be expensive, and consumers may waste money by replacing devices that could have been repaired or upgraded. On the other hand, consumers can also waste money repairing devices that are no longer worth maintaining. TechTrade helps reduce this uncertainty by giving users a structured way to evaluate their options and make better financial decisions. The product also addresses an emotional problem: **the uncertainty and frustration of making an expensive technology purchase or repair decision.**

6. Is your product easy to monetize?

TechTrade has several potential monetization opportunities. One possibility would be affiliate partnerships with electronics retailers. If TechTrade recommends replacing a device, the website could provide links to relevant products and receive a commission from purchases. Another possibility would be partnerships with repair services. If TechTrade determines that a device should be repaired, the user could be connected with a participating repair provider. Other potential revenue sources could include sponsored listings, referral fees from trade-in or resale services, or premium features. However, the initial version of TechTrade would not need to implement these monetization methods. The goal of the class project is to demonstrate the product concept and user experience.

7. Is your product simple and easy to describe?

Yes. The basic concept can be described in one sentence:

TechTrade helps you decide whether to repair, upgrade, sell, or replace your electronics.

This simplicity is vital to convey the product's overall benefit towards the end user. The user does not need to understand how TechTrade works internally, they only need to provide information about their device and receive a recommendation.

The four possible outcomes also make the product easy to understand:

REPAIR | UPGRADE | SELL | REPLACE

This could become a central part of the website's branding and user interface.

8. Who will be the likely users of your product? Does it have a large market?

The likely users of TechTrade are everyday consumers who own electronic devices and eventually face questions about whether those devices are still worth keeping.

Potential users include:

- College students
- Parents
- Smartphone owners
- Laptop and desktop users
- Gamers
- People with aging electronics
- People who are not highly knowledgeable about technology

- Consumers trying to save money on technology purchases

The potential market is large because electronics are widely used by consumers. Almost everyone who owns a smartphone, computer, tablet, gaming system, or other electronic device will eventually need to decide whether to repair, upgrade, sell, or replace it. The product could initially focus on common consumer electronics such as smartphones and laptops and potentially expand into other categories later.

9. Does your product have a legitimate secret sauce?

TechTrade's secret sauce would not be the simple act of recommending whether someone should repair or replace a device. Similar information exists in many places. Instead, the unique value would come from **combining several pieces of information into one simple recommendation.**

TechTrade would consider factors such as:

- Device age
- Current condition
- Performance
- Repair cost
- Upgradeability
- Estimated remaining lifespan
- Resale value
- Replacement cost
- The user's actual needs

The most important difference is that TechTrade would not assume that buying a new product is the best answer. Its core philosophy would be: **The best technology purchase might be no purchase at all.** If a \$100 upgrade can extend the useful life of a \$1,000 laptop for another two years, TechTrade should be able to recognize that. If a device is severely outdated and a repair would cost almost as much as replacing it, TechTrade should be able to recognize that as well. This decision-making process is what would differentiate TechTrade from a standard electronics retailer or product comparison website.

Conclusion

TechTrade is a consumer technology decision-making tool designed to help people make better decisions about their existing electronics. Rather than simply encouraging consumers to buy new products, TechTrade evaluates whether a device should be repaired, upgraded, sold, or replaced.

The idea is primarily a **Simplify** and **Remix** product because it simplifies a complicated decision and combines information that consumers would normally have to research across multiple sources.

The concept is personally relevant to me because technology is an important part of my everyday life and job, and I am interested in understanding the value, performance, and lifespan of electronic devices. Most importantly, TechTrade provides a focused problem that can be represented effectively through an interactive website, making it a practical product concept for this course.